Chapter Sixty-Four

The Sultan and the Khan

Between 1310 and 1335,
the empire of Egypt grows in strength and wealth,
but the Il-khanate collapses

KHALIL, THE SULTAN OF EGYPT, had presided over the final end of the last Crusader kingdom: the goal of Muslim commanders since the days of Saladin.

This did not make him a hero. Instead, he was assassinated in 1293, aged twenty-nine, by three of his own officers.

In the seventeen anarchic years that followed, the sultanate changed hands four times. Self-made men, rising from slavery to sultanate, the mamluks of Egypt had no tradition of father-to-son succession: the strongest man was the one who could lay hold of the sultan's scepter. And although all of the would-be rulers were mamluk, none of them belonged to the Bahri Regiment, the onetime personal bodyguard of long-dead Ayyub. Even the Bahri who had been very young men at the time of the Regiment's rise to power, were in their seventies; the next generation of mamluks was now agitating for its share of power.[1]

Complicating the struggle for power at the top was the existence of Qalawun's younger son, Khalil's little brother al-Nasir Muhammad ibn Qalawun. Al-Nasir, only eight at the time of Khalil's murder, was elevated to the sultanate twice between 1293 and 1310, both times as a figurehead; power